IT is early March, spring is in the air and the mahua trees are in full bloom, their reddish hue a striking contrast to the luminescent green of the sal forest in the Bastar region of the central Indian state of Chhattisgarh. From the window of the BSF (Border Security Force) chopper hovering above, the river Indravati looks like a blue ribbon wrapped around a brilliant tapestry of nature. The serenity, though, is deceptive. In the forbidding jungles below, central and state armed police forces are engaged in a grim, bloody battle against a determined band of violent left-wing extremists (LWE), or Naxals, who posed the biggest internal security challenge in India for the past six decades.

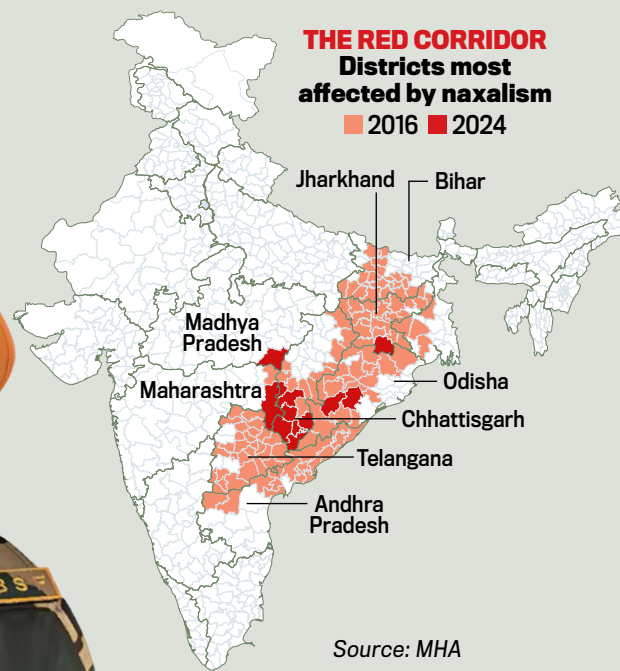
It is a war that has exacted a dismaying toll. In the past 20 years, 2,344 security personnel have lost their lives fighting Naxals—more than four times the number of Indian army personnel killed in the 1999 Kargil War. In fact, more armed personnel have died fighting Naxals than battling terrorists in Jammu and Kashmir, which till recently was the country's other big internal security threat. The civilian toll is extremely high, too—6,258 people have been killed in Naxal attacks in the past two decades alone.

At its peak, the Naxal threat impacted 80 million people, mainly tribals. It straddled 10 states along a narrow Red Corridor running across Andhra Pradesh, Bihar, Chhattisgarh, Jharkhand, Madhya Pradesh, Maharashtra, Odisha, Telangana, West Bengal and Uttar Pradesh. Or from Pashupati in Nepal to Tirupati in Andhra, as Union home minister Amit Shah put it. The tide has been turning, though,



THE GUNS AND GULAB POLICY

With a mix of anti-Naxal offensives and development initiatives, the Modi government is reclaiming territory and heralding peace



Source: MHA

"I give a guarantee to parents that I will root out Naxalism. I assure mothers that the lives of their children will not go to waste"

— NARENDRA MODI
Prime Minister, in Dhamtara, Chhattisgarh, Apr. 23, 2024

